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Pierre Boussaguet

Bassist Pierre Boussaguet was born in Albi, France in 1962. He has recorded and performed with the best jazz artists from both America and Europe, including Lalo Schifrin, Ray Brown and Guy Lafitte.

Pierre was interviewed in Aix en Provence, France on 7/28/2020 by Matthieu Jaffre.

MJ: Hello. We are here today at the Fola Jazz Club in Aix en Provence in the south of France. We are filming for Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm delighted today to welcome Pierre Boussaguet. Pierre Boussaguet, hello. How are you doing?

PB: Fine, great. And you?

MJ: Fine, thank you. Well before, to start things off, I just wrote down a short list of musicians you worked with during your career, and I'd like to enumerate some of them. There's Milt Jackson, Harry Edison, Clark Terry, Johnny Griffin, Tommy Flanagan, Phil Woods, Bob Berg, Lou Donaldson, Hank Jones, and it goes on and on and on and on. What an impressive list. You must have so many memories, working with all those giants of jazz.

PB: Yes of course, and I would say that I was young and old at the same time. What I mean is that when I started at that time, when I started to be really crazy, just crazy banana about jazz, the only thing we had was records. LPs and tapes. That was it. And especially being from the southwest of France there were no jazz schools. There was maybe at that time, when I moved to Paris in '85 they started to have one jazz school over there. So it's just to describe — so in other words whenever you, each of us, we wanted to get some information I would say that the talent was to have the nose and to know who to call and where to go, take the car and drive to speak to that one person, he's got that record by Duke Ellington, or he knows about that tune. That was a trick. Now today it's the other way around with — I'm not criticizing I'm just observing it and I keep saying that to all students, I believe that talent today is to select information. Because way too much information, so the goal now I would say, if I was 20 years old today it's to have the discipline to say do I really need that and that and that. Because you need — it's important to focus on one thing. So, and to answer your question, what — to me the jazz school was to be in a café, to be on a train, to be driving, to be on the road for five hours per day, and that's where you hear all of those stories. Most of them are very funny but you discover the only major big tree of who is who, who played what, who created that, and I got lucky to — I don't know the reason but I got so lucky to be around all these old

musicians. And the more, with the years — it's been years — and now when I think of it, I mean I played a few tunes one time with Big Joe Turner.

MJ: Wow. Impressive.

PB: Stride piano player. I mean when I look at pictures in the book I say, yeah, I know this guy. I remember Dickie Thompson, a guitarist, and so on.

MJ: What was your first jazz record that you listened when you were young?

PB: Well in my small town I was maybe 15 or 16 years old, 15 I guess, no 14. And there was a new shop that opened nearby my parents' house. And it was a very small shop and they started to sell, what you call it, equipment. Sound equipment. And just a few records. And I remember there may be three boxes of LPs. And I saw something saying jazz there. They had classical, rock or pop, and jazz. So I didn't know — at that time I didn't know anything about it. Some friends told me you should investigate it, because I used to play accordion for dancing parties. And I didn't even move to the bass. And I remember that — I looked at the covers and they were beautiful. I love LPs because of the size of it.

MJ: Sure.

PB: And I saw, it was a black and white picture and it was filled up with the face of one guy. That guy was Harry "Sweets" Edison.

MJ: Harry Edison, yeah.

PB: And I remember, I went to the cashier, to cash the record and the guy told me, he said, "Wow, you buy this record, do you know it?" I said, "I have no idea what this guy, what kind of music he plays, but the expression of the face for some reason I felt like he was doing that."

MJ: Yeah, a hug.

PB: That was a record under the name of Sweets, a quintet with Eddie "Lockjaw" Davis, Oliver Jackson drums, beautiful piano player Gerry Wiggins, and Major Holley on bass.

MJ: And so you were born in 1962 in the southwest of France. Can you describe the jazz scene at that time when you grew up in that region?

PB: In my city and basically all the cities let's say in the big southwest of France, you had the two clans. And I escaped from both of them. On one side you had what they called the traditional Hot Club de France, would tend to be very conservative at that time; and on the other side you had, how we say, public places. When I say public I mean like they're an institution like the Ministry of Culture, and at that time in France since the Boris Vian, since let's say the 50s, they started to have like the North Pole and the South Pole.

MJ: Dixieland, New Orleans, kind of beboppers.

PB: So some, to make it as a caricature, as some people put, they say that jazz was over when Charlie Parker appeared. And some others believed that jazz was born with John Coltrane

love the most is played in between. So anyway, that was the context. So I went to the Hot Club because that was the only thing in my city. The guy was very nice and that was like, that was like a school. Because he used to invite me every week, once a week, and say, "Okay now today we're going to listen to Louis Armstrong with the Hot 5 or 7, then you need to know about Benny Carter, then you need to know about Earl Hines. And up to Charlie Parker. And I remember when I started to face the problem between so-called modern people or so-called traditionalists I just realized it was the first time I had the chance to go to the main city, Toulouse, which at that time was really a trip, with the authorizations with my parents and everything, I took a train for the first time.

MJ: Wow, liberty.

PB: Yeah. I mean the new world. And of course the first thing I did in Toulouse is to buy a couple of records.

MJ: Yeah, sure.

PB: And I bought that great Coleman Hawkins/Howard McGhee record with Tommy Potter.

MJ: So during the late 40s I guess, middle.

PB: Yeah. Beginning of the 50s. Art Blakey of course. And —

MJ: Some of the youngsters, beboppers from that time.

PB: Yeah. So at that time you select a record, you go to the guy of the shop and you ask him, I don't know about it — he'd play a few notes, you say okay, I want it.

MJ: I like it. I want to buy it.

PB: Or, I don't know, and you'd try something else. So I went back home with that Coleman Hawkins and I was so proud because the guy has teach me about Coleman Hawkins. "Body and Soul," like in '37, all of that. And when I got home with the new record that I bought, I'm very proud. Like I am nourishing a new regime with a teacher. And when I got, the next week, he said, "Oh you bought some records. What is that?" He said, "Oh bad luck?" You bought a record where, that's an area where Coleman Hawkins started to play not only jazz. And somewhere, I tell this whole story because it can happen today, which any form of music or art. Like someone is dogmatic. I can't stand that. You listen to something, it speaks to you or not, but you can't judge a music, like who can judge if one music is better than the other one.

MJ: No you can't. It appeals to you and you like it right away.

PB: And my revelation at that time, I remember, I got really upset when he said, "It's not your fault, you didn't pick out the right record." Because on one side I trusted his judgement. But on the other side I said, "I'm not fooled." I went back home and played the record again for the thirtieth time in that week, and I loved it.

MJ: The more I listen to it the more I like it.

PB: Yeah. So somewhere I realized that you have your little voice. Your heart was telling you one thing, and then adults, you're still a kid, still young, they tell you different things. This is good; this is bad. And that's where I started to unconsciously to say no, I must follow that little voice.

MJ: My little voice, my inside, yeah.

PB: Yeah. Call it intuition or whatever. But then within a few years I started to jam with people and everything and I realized immediately, with the first musicians — professional I mean — that I met, none of them was like that. It was the people speaking about the music, not the musicians.

MJ: Can you describe for us how you came to the bass, and how was your first gig as a jazz player?

PB: So the first question is how I moved from accordion to the bass. My teacher on accordion, you know especially for dancing music you play only the right hand because you have a rhythm section so you don't need to play the chords and the bass on the left. And that was much more interesting unconsciously with the harmonies on any waltz or any dancing song, I would stop my teacher and say, "Yeah but you know this is not good, you put a C on the bass then we move to F and you should put a C5 augmented to move there because of the melody." And one day he told me, he said, "I don't get it. You're supposed to play the right hand and your brain, your spirit, your focus is on harmony, about the bass note. He said, "Well if you want to play some kind of modern instrument, you should just move to electric bass," and he told me what I called the sweetest lie I heard in my life. He told me, he said, "I guarantee if you practice half an hour for two months, the bass, it's nothing.

MJ: It's okay, very simple.

PB: I believed him.

MJ: You tried it?

PB: Yes, but after two months I realized that it was not that easy.

MJ: Okay.

PB: So basically, to answer your question, I was, for some reason, I was interested a lot in the fundamentals of music and the harmony, which is actually I discovered later on, that's the job of a bassist. It's not just to play a groove. To me that's totally wrong. It's to create a fundamental voice that is a voice by itself but always nourishing what the orchestra says, help the soloist of trying — exactly like Ron Carter put it just in a few words, I'm talking too much, Ron Carter said, "Our job is to find the good notes." That's perfect. So from then on I switched to bass and the Hot Club at that time. That was my first jazz concert in the theater. I didn't want to go because at that time because at that time I didn't know

was playing accordion. I was not at all, the very few pieces that my sister used to listen to about classical music, that was okay. I could say I liked it but not enough to buy records or to want to know what was this music about. And jazz, I had no idea. To me, jazz maybe I would, have associated it with Glenn Miller. Maybe the name of Louis Armstrong.

MJ: So you didn't fall in love with jazz right away.

PB: No. And so when they said, "Oh there is a jazz concert" — it was my best buddy in school, "you have to come." And I'd say, "Oh it's during the week, my parents they would never accept that." "I'll speak to your parents" so we'll arrange it. And I remember that when I got there it was the little Italian theater, which I'm in love with that, and what I like is that the Italian theater, instead of having the people from the stage going far, because of the balconies you have everybody —

MJ: Just in front of you.

PB: Yeah. So you create, to me you create some kind of ball of —

MJ: Proximity.

PB: Proximity, yeah. So anyway the master of ceremony for the concert, it was the boss of the Hot Club there, he said, "Okay tonight ladies and gentlemen, welcome. Please welcome, on the drums Mr. — I remember the name — Mr. Bill English. From backstage I see a gentleman, sitting up, taking a bow, picking up a pair of sticks, and he sounded [scats]. And then while playing the hi-hat, the guy announces that on bass we have a gentleman, his name, please welcome Mr. Jimmy Rowser, never heard of. And I see this big guy with, I noticed the detail, I loved it, he had red leather shoes. To me, wow, that's hip. And I remember he picked up the bass, turned on the amp, and I remember the best line he played, he played [scats] —

MJ: Okay. Walking bass. Yeah. The first time you heard the double bass.

PB: And for some reason, I don't know, the brain, the heart, knocked me down. And my friend at that time told me years ago he said, "You just grabbed my hand," that I don't remember, and you said, "this is what I want to do." So that was my —

MJ: It was pretty strong, yeah.

PB: And the piano player, I forget.

MJ: From then you knew that's how you wanted to play the double bass.

PB: From the trio. He introduced the drummer, Bill English, Jimmy Rowser on bass, and the piano player leading the trio was Ray Bryant.

MJ: What years was that? Do you remember? In the 70s?

PB: 1982 maybe. '81 — or no I would say 1980. And then later on I had a chance to play a few times with Ray Bryant. And of course I told him that memory and his conclusion was

colleagues, he said, "You see, it doesn't matter where you're playing. You could be in a big stadium, you could be in a very small, tiny joint, you have no idea of who is in the audience listening." So that's why you have to be focused on the music.

MJ: For sure. In my list I didn't mention one particular musician that you worked with for several years that you really admire, it's Ray Brown. And I know that the owner of this place, Jean-Paul Artero gave you an advice in the 80s to maybe work with him, so it's part of your relationship.

PB: It's his fault.

MJ: It's his fault, yeah.

PB: So actually what happened is that I remember I played a concert at a jazz festival in the middle of France in a city called Clermont-Ferrand, and the jazz director, the director of the festival that night we were hanging out after the concert, and he said, "Wow why don't you propose Ray Brown to play some duets with you?" Okay? And the next day I was here in Aix en Provence with Jean Paul where we're at — and at the end of the night he told me the same thing. And then the next day I went back to Paris and another person told me the same thing. And I said uh oh.

MJ: It's too much.

PB: It's too much. So I dared, I knew Ray at that time but I dared to call him and he was coming to Paris a few days after that. And I said, "Ray" I said, "Raymond" I used to call him Raymond. I said, "Raymond I've got to ask you a question" I said, "but please don't be mad at me." He said, "No, what is it?"

MJ: Go on.

PB: I told him that you know it's been three guys who told me that we should do something with two basses and his reaction was fantastic. He just said, "Great." He took a napkin, he wrote the numbers 1-2-3-4- until 10 on the left side. On the right side he put PB, he put RB, then [claps] cut the paper in two, napkin, and he said, okay you pick up ten tunes and you arrange them for two basses and I do so.

MJ: As a young musician it should be the most amazing advice —

PB: I was on the floor.

MJ: And I mean this is such an unusual gig to play with two double bass. So for him to accept it it's unbelievable.

PB: It's not easy to talk about yourself but Ray was a super person in terms, not only a musician but —

MJ: As a person.

PB: As a person. Very smart. So if he didn't expect to have some fun or what kind of interest, he would just say no.

PB: And I was already a student and I remember the second time I saw him, he was really impressed. He said, "How could you achieve such amount of work in one year?" He said, "What did you do?" And I said, "Well I just practiced your lessons."

MJ: What did you learn with him, I mean working with him and doing two albums with him as a bass player and as a humankind?

PB: What did I learn? Of course which is very, so rare, what you mentioned, that when you are a bassist and you play with another bassist, no other words, you find a common path and basically with such a personality and such a giant like Ray, the past was already done. So unconsciously you just, it's like if you take a ski lesson you just path where the monitor is passing.

MJ: Okay. You follow the path?

PB: Yeah but year after year, week after week, doing that unconsciously, this path starts to become so natural. At that time I didn't realize it. It was years after I said wow, I got lucky. I mean it's like if you would be a piano player and you play a duet with Hank Jones or Tommy Flanagan —

MJ: It's crazy.

PB: Or whoever you want, and you play every day for two, three, four hours. And you do that for a month.

MJ: Yeah, and you were touring in Europe.

PB: You don't even think about where should I place the beat, you just go, and it becomes natural. So I learned that. But many other things. Ray was very also trying to educate about I would say today, the business side of things.

MJ: Okay. About being a musician?

PB: Yeah.

MJ: He told you about how to —

PB: Not in terms of negotiation or stuff like that but just to — one time — I will put it this way. One time we had an argument. And at some point I faced him and I said, "What do you expect from me?" I said, "I heard, you keep repeating that, I know what you're talking about so tell me what should I do?" And he cracked up laughing and he said, with his cap he just banged me on the shoulder and he said, "I'm trying to help you. You and young musicians. I don't want you, all of you guys, to do the same errors we did.

MJ: Yeah. To be ripped off.

PB: Exactly. Wow, that's such a gift. And that's being so intelligent.

MJ: That's true.

PB: See I don't want you to — he learned me a lot of things. For instance, one time we were driving. I was doing the driving. We were playing that night, then dealing with the

one time we had the day off, we traveled and we used that day to travel for five or six hours. And when we got there, we arrived in Switzerland I remember. It was like 3:30, 4 in the afternoon. And at that time he said, "What you doing?" I said, "Ah, I'm going to rest in my room." He said, "No." He said, "Look, it's springtime, come on, let's have a drink." A drink at that time? He said —

MJ: It's not too early.

PB: No, no, he said, "This is your day off."

MJ: And to enjoy it.

PB: You've been working hard for the past ten days, so if there is one day to have a nice scotch or a vodka or whatever, and an ice cream, that's the moment. And then later on you go to bed and you rest. That type of things. But never, never with a preaching attitude. Just, it was —

MJ: Spontaneous and very natural.

PB: It's like today most of the knowledge, you can find everything you want in a book, which I'm not against, it's great. We didn't have that information. Today you can have it.

MJ: You can have it.

PB: But what still you need is being around the people. Recording with Ray I was very observing — the way he arrives to the studio, what he does. I noted that he didn't drink tons of coffee, or he didn't smoke tons of cigarettes before recording.

MJ: Very professional.

PB: Yes, and all these little things, oh, that's the way to deal with it. How to read music.

MJ: So you learned by his behavior as daily life, yeah.

PB: Exactly.

MJ: Okay. Talking about your discography, there is one particular album that I really like, it was released in 1998, it's called "Charme."

PB: Oh.

MJ: I like it very much because you are playing with Herve Sellin and Alvin Queen, the trio. You performed a lot in the 90s with, especially Alvin Queen.

PB: Yes. My big brother.

MJ: Yeah, a video on YouTube where you are playing with Clark Terry and Dado Moroni. He's swinging fantastic. And yeah, I like this concert particularly.

PB: Me too.

MJ: You too? In this record you can really feel the chemistry between the three of you. And in one tune, "Sister Jones," you are kind of humming and scatting the notes while you are performing the solo. And this is a kind of a tradition like from the 40s. Slam Stewart used to do it with the Archer. So I was wondering, in this album, was it spontaneously that it

PB: No I didn't plan it. Sometimes I can describe, there is not a concept. Sometimes when I play a solo I might suddenly be feeling like if I am leaded by the voice. So I can [scats] — so it's like basically unconsciously I'm playing what I am singing, or singing — some other time I don't sing at all and I might be thinking about the line or a chord. And that day I remember that we were in the middle of the tune and it was — it's one of these tunes where you don't feel like you're in the studio. You feel it's like your opening tune, you're on stage, the clapping starts and —

MJ: You perform.

PB: Yeah. Let's perform. And so when I started to be humming, the only thing I remember is that I said no, no. Don't try to control it. Let it go.

MJ: Let loose.

PB: Yeah. Let it go. And then when we listened to it nobody said anything.

MJ: It happened so spontaneously. You can hear it on the record.

PB: You'd have to record another track.

MJ: No. Nobody said that. Mouth shut.

PB: It just happened that way.

MJ: Okay. And in one tune you're performing also with a great tenor saxophonist Guy Lafitte, before he just passed away a few months later.

PB: A few weeks.

MJ: A few weeks later. Wow. So you were like the last?

PB: He didn't want — he was already very sick at home. He knew that he had just a few weeks.

MJ: You can't hear it, that he was sick, on the record.

PB: And what happened is that the night before I called him another time and said, "Guy, come to the studio tomorrow." And I remember he yelled at me on the phone but like he was crying. He said, "You don't understand that, I can't play, it's been two months, I can't blow one tune." And for some reason I said —

MJ: It's painful?

PB: No he couldn't.

MJ: He couldn't.

PB: He was too fragile to even — and I remember telling him it takes some guts. But of course, I said, "You know what? Forget about the saxophone. But why you don't pass through the studio and say good-bye to your friends?" And then I said, "Why don't you write a text, some poetry." Because he was very gifted about that. And he said, "What kind of poetry?" I said, "Anything, a text, if you have something, and come to say hello to us." And so he said, he called me back maybe ten or half an hour, he said, "I'll be there

that piece of music, the ballad called "Charme." Actually when I wrote the music, those weeks, I wanted to make a reunion of Guy Lafitte and Johnny Griffin. Because they knew each other since ever. But they never played together or just one concert, something like that. And then of course Guy got sick like early April I would say. And so, but I had written that ballad. The original title was "Griff and Guy." Like Griffin and Guy. G and G. And then I asked Guy, with his beautiful poetry, which the text is a metaphor about how to describe the life of one note. And then he said, "I should try the saxophone." And he did it. That one track. Then we tried another track and he couldn't.

MJ: But he performed it very well. I mean we can really feel his emotions.

PB: And I'm so glad at that point on the phone, not being shy.

MJ: But you insisted.

PB: I had to insist but I don't know, I know what to say, that in some ways it was one more time that little voice that told me it's the moment to push a little bit.

MJ: I mean he is in the pure tradition of the great tenor saxophone like Coleman Hawkins, Don Byas, Lucky Thompson, you can really feel the deep sounds in him.

PB: I'll tell you a story. A few weeks after that, one of the shows that was supposed to be performed with my trio and Johnny Griffin and Guy, of course Guy was just a few days before going to pass away. And I still had that concert to play with Griff. So I remember I was down by his house in the middle of the west part of France. So I go to Griff's house. And he said, I stayed at his house, and he said, "Okay tomorrow we take my wife's car and you and I will drive to the concert." And when we got there we were really in advance like maybe two in the afternoon and sound check was at five. So he says, "Baby, what about a drink?" I said, "Okay." So we were in a private salon in the hotel and I remember talking about Guy at some point. He said, he said, "Pierre, you have to face a tough period." I said, "What you mean?" He said, "Well, I know you love first class Bordeaux wine." He says, "So do I." He said, "You don't realize that you've been performing for the past ten years with a premier grand cru sound of the saxophone. Because Guy —

MJ: That's very true.

PB: So true. A beautiful tone. So he told me he said, "I take a number. It will take you approximately ten years to be able to accept mentally to deal with another tenor saxophonist." On the spot I said wow, if he tells me so, I remember — but somewhere, no, life has to move on. And in fact that's the way it happened. And it took me maybe seven, eight, nine hours [years] I didn't count — but I always — there was one day —

MJ: So Johnny Griffin is the one who told you try to bring the —

PB: He told me he said Guy Lafitte is one of the first five premier grand cru, such a beautiful

MJ: He was very right.

PB: But the message, the message was that you got used to that. Because every time I played with a tenor there was —

MJ: Not realize it, yeah.

PB: And I must say, I've seen that beautiful interview about Sweets, talking about the sound. All these cats, I would say these cats, that's a word we used, but to me all of these masters, the force — and I'm not a traditionalist, I'm not avante garde.

MJ: They have their own sounds.

PB: You play two notes —

MJ: You can recognize them.

PB: You know if it's Johnny Hodges. If we talk about alto you know if it's Art Pepper. If it's Phil Woods, Charlie Parker.

MJ: That's true.

PB: Cannonball Adderley. I mean all of them. And with Guy you hear just that one note, it's not even part of the note he's playing —

MJ: The feeling, the emotion, yeah, the tone he's using is very deep. You worked also with people working for soundtracks on movies and films like Michel Legrand — I'd like you to tell a few words about Michel. How was your experience working with such a great composer?

PB: Amazing. And actually I'm trying not to explain but I'm trying to, like everybody things is happening in their life, and personally, just for myself, I'm trying to understand, to put some sense on it — not necessary to explain do we have the explanation of life? It's a big gamble. But I started first of all because of Ray Brown I started to work with this amazing composer, arranger, orchestrator person, Lalo Schifrin.

MJ: Yes.

PB: And the way it happened that I remember, I was home, Ray Brown called and I said, ahh, so when you're young and the phone is ringing, it's Ray Brown calling you, it's already a day of celebration.

MJ: For sure.

PB: So I said, "So Raymond, what's up?" He said, "Get your book." I said, "Okay." He said, "Are you free July" dot dot dot "these days?" "Yeah I am."

MJ: You'd be working with Lalo Schifrin.

PB: No, no, he didn't tell me that. He said, "Okay, could you hold these three, four days and I'll call you back in about maximum give me one week."

MJ: Mmm, that surprise.

PB: I said, "All right."

PB: And then he told me that it was to work with Johnny Griffin [Lalo Schifrin] and I remember, he said, "Oh by the way," he said, "one question. How is your reading?"

MJ: Wow, put pressure on you.

PB: That was it, it was a challenge. And so everything went very greatly with Lalo and then for the past ten, fifteen years Lalo calls me regularly and we became good friends. We still communicate. He's an amazing person, him and his wife, Donna. But if I mention him before Michel, because if I had not worked —

MJ: With Lalo Schifrin before.

PB: With Lalo, I don't think I would have been able to work with Michel. First of all, to have some sense of dealing with an orchestra. And then specifically about Michel, it has been ten years of, most of the time, always a challenge. But I would say a fantastic, profound, and so high demanding challenge. But you go for it. Because Michel, even himself he was very conscious about, he could have such a temper with anybody. But it was never, never personal. To him, he has written something so the first letter of the music, it has to sound perfect like he has conceived it. And he can't accept that you need to deal, you need to work on it to get it. So some people are very, I heard that some people are very criticizing to say well this is a kind of childish attitude. Of course it is. But the reason he did that, if you challenge that you discover parts of yourself that you're not aware of.

MJ: That's true.

PB: And the best example, I remember one time we did some tour in Russia. And it's time to go for dinner after a long day of rehearsing, recording, etcetera. And Michel and I, we were on the pavement in front of the hotel and we're expecting the limousine to take us to something. And at that time he had me playing on one track electric bass. I touch the electric bass maybe every two, three years when there is one guy — I play electric bass with two guys in my life: Lalo Schifrin or Michel Legrand.

MJ: Or Michel Legrand.

PB: That's it. Nobody calls me for that, but anyway, I would love to, but anyway, and I knew I had the challenge. And not to play chords or a groove, but he had written — so it was a part, a real bass part. Of course a few weeks, just maybe the week before going there I'm like that.

MJ: Yeah. Started to feel a little bit —

PB: I don't consider — the rest of the tunes could be a terrible key, I didn't care. But having to deal with an instrument that I'm not an expert of.

MJ: The electric bass.

PB: And so we finished that day, so that day we finished the recording. He didn't say anything about the bass. Whew.

PB: What he proposed, let's speak downstairs and let's go for dinner. Yes. And we were walking on the pavement and I say, "Michel," I say, "I want to thank you because I couldn't imagine that one day I could be in Moscow, Russia, sight seeing a bass part on electric bass. You know what was his answer? He said, "Tsk, tsk, you got it wrong." He said, "The only thing you have to get from this experience is that if you did it for me it means you have it into you that means that you can do it. That was his generosity.

MJ: Yes, very profound, yeah. Around this period you also went to publishing a bass learning methods also, so I'd like to know what brought you to publish a method for the bass players?

PB: It started very early and for some reason I was maybe at that time, whenever I had a chance to have a lesson like with Ray or with Jimmy Woode in the beginning, of course I took a piece of paper and, trying to memorize what the person has given to you. So okay, so basically we spoke about that, we spoke about that. Okay. You take notes. And then it became an habit. Whenever I would get a lesson from somebody, or I would give a lesson, when I started to have a few students, or I would be witnessing, like if you are bass teacher yourself and you have a class in the conservatory, it happened to me a few times, you're inviting me as a guest to observe. The way you're going to solve a problem for a student, the way a student will react to it, I will take note of it. And one day it was in 2008 I think, it was like I had a few weeks off in early summer, and I found that box filled up with notes. And just for myself I decided to put them in order, and little by little. But I knew for some way, intuition, I knew I wanted to accomplish that book. And when the book was issued in fact to me it's a continuation of Ray Brown's bass book. Because any question, I didn't understand into his book, I forced myself to try to find an answer. And with the years I realized that as a caricature, we spoke about that. Ray didn't know about my bass book because at that time he had gone already. But we spoke about that. And he spoke. And we spoke about his book. He said, "You know I did it pretty fast basically," he said, "I just laid down a couple of technical stuff. But for instance you have a chapter on blues. And you have blues 1 [scats] very, very basic lines. Blues number 2, you have already [scats].

MJ: Adding more notes, yeah.

PB: And the third blues is already much more complex. The problem is that how do you get from blues 1 to blues 2? And each of us who studied with this book run into the same problem. So I suspect that unconsciously I decided to write the in between exercises.

MJ: Okay.

PB: And so I wanted to do the angle of the book is to develop your ear while learning how to play the instrument. At the same time it nourishes each other.

PB: While you're playing you're learning how to play technically the instrument, you develop your ear as to become a bassist. So this is not a book to become a super soloist, it's a book about to be a bassist. Because my first teacher, a classical teacher, told me that the first lesson. He didn't know anything about jazz. It was just classical.

MJ: Was it Jean Cros?

PB: Jean Cros. Amazing guy. 82 years old. He told me, he said, "Before we proceed for the first lesson, you have to be very careful and to answer yes to this question, do you want to become a good bassist or do you want to play greatly bass? And I said, "Well if I may say I'd like to be both. He said, "That's a good answer." So he said, "If you want to play, if you and I tonight we want to go out and listen to great bass playing we simply go to the opera house." That's great bass. He said, "Now if tonight we decided to listen to a great bassist," he said, "there is only one: Johann Sebastian Bach."

MJ: Yes, for sure.

PB: I think about that, referring to my other master, Ron Carter, it's okay you have to play the bass, some people can be like, it's like on the piano, Oscar Peterson explained that so well. Some people play great music just with a few notes. Count Basie. Oscar, for some reason, he's got more to say. But the point is that the artistry of someone is not the quantity of the notes, it's what you say. And for the bass line it's the same. Ray used to tell me about Ron Carter, and I love the simple image. He said, "You see," he said, "Niels Henning, Oscar Peterson.

MJ: Yes. A great bass player.

PB: He makes his career using that of the fingerboard. He said, "Personally," he said, "I use that." He said, "Now if you take Ron, he's the best, he uses that."

MJ: Just the upper part of the instrument.

PB: But if you think about the image, it's brilliant.

MJ: That's true.

PB: So that's why in my book I wanted to really, trying to find answers about — what I miss also with that, I grew up with all these, Count Basie records. And especially I wrote about that. When you listen to any bassist playing with the orchestra, in Basie's band the bass line is not the bass line. It's like a counterpoint voice, which still has the function of a bass line. The bass is singing. And as a caricature today we put the bass just as a groove. So you spend the whole tune just playing [scats], which is great, but, and then you let all the other instruments play harmony. With Basie, you didn't have that.

MJ: That's true. Well, Pierre, we are unfortunately coming to the end of our program. I could have gone asking so many more questions. I have one last question. Last but not least. If you were to take a jazz record on a desert island, what record would it be?

MJ: That's the tricky part.

PB: And jazz, so already I don't have to deal with a classical record or a song record.

MJ: Only jazz.

PB: Only jazz?

MJ: A Count Basie record?

PB: No I think one of two records. Either I take one or the other. Because I'm trying to think of all the records that's got in itself everything I like. I will take the "Trumpet Summit Meets Oscar Peterson Big Four." That's a session that was done in one night in Hollywood. Dizzy flew especially for the session and flew right back after the session.

MJ: What year was it?

PB: I would say by memory around early 80s. Oscar Peterson, Joe Pass,

MJ: Okay, Ray Brown?

PB: Ray Brown, Bobby Durham, and then Freddie Hubbard, Dizzy Gillespie —

MJ: Wow.

PB: And Clark Terry.

MJ: Gosh. I never heard about this record.

PB: Oh God. And they play eight bar blues, which is kind of rare, which is called "Chicken Wings." It's amazing.

MJ: Okay. What's the name of that tune?

PB: "Chicken Wings."

MJ: Okay. I'll check it out.

PB: The arrangement is so well done, like you have "If I Remember Well," that's Freddie Hubbard first who started a duet with —

MJ: With Dizzy?

PB: No, no, no. You're getting me confused.

MJ: With another trumpet player?

PB: Freddie Hubbard with Oscar, then the rhythm section comes, then after two or three choruses they change keys, a second soloist is arriving, Dizzy with Joe Pass. No, no, first of all, that's, okay, no. I've got it wrong. That's Dizzy with Joe Pass and then another soloist starting with the piano, and the last of it is Clark Terry. And when Clark, I mean the three guys, the three masters, they played —

MJ: Playing together.

PB: I can't decide if I prefer these or Freddie —

MJ: Chemistry.

PB: Or Clark. But there is one thing, and that's what I get from all this.

MJ: It swings a lot.

PB: Musicians from that time, when Clark arrives it's in D flat. The blues is in D flat. I mean you feel it's like a church. There was a communion. And that album is fantastic.

MJ: I know what you mean.

PB: And the second album I would think of, it's "Ellington Big Four." You know that record?

MJ: I'm not sure about that, no.

PB: Duke, Joe Pass, Louie Bellson, Ray Brown.

MJ: Wow. A small formation, okay.

PB: Basically it's a jam session.

MJ: Okay.

PB: There is one tune great, it's written I think by Louie Bellson. And you can hear Louie Bellson telling the chords before the bridge: B flat, A flat.

MJ: Louie Bellson on drums? Wow. Well Pierre, we came to the end of our program. I'd like to thank you once again for being here with us today because it wasn't easy with the Covid-19 pandemic to be with us today. So I'd like to thank the Fola Jazz Club once again also for welcoming us, and good-bye for now.

PB: Good-bye, it's been such an honor and a pleasure because you made me realize that I got so lucky to be around all these people at that time, and I still do performing on the road. Just last night I was watching two of Monk interviews, one by Ray Brown that I didn't know about yet, and one by Sweets Edison. So you helped me to do some kind of —

MJ: Yeah. I mixed up both characters in the interview.

PB: And especially it's an honor because jazz to me, being open, jazz has always been, historically speaking, it's a pure American art form. That is so powerful, so joyful, that it spread out throughout the world and today you have jazz musicians all over the planet.

MJ: That's true.

PB: Joe Pass was telling me years ago about that. And from my point of view, I'm not American. It happened that I am French and so European, but I've seen the way so many concerts, and the way that jazz has been always loved and protected in Europe. It makes me logical to have the opportunity, and thank you for that, to speak to my brother American musicians about somewhere — we are on the same train on a different car. I will put it this way. But to me that train, call it the A train if you want.

MJ: Yeah, it goes to the same direction, yeah.

PB: Yeah it's one thing.

MJ: Well thank you very much, Pierre.

PB: You're welcome.

MJ: And good-bye. Thank you for watching.

PB: Good-bye.